



The Parent Communication Toolkit:

How to Wow Families this School Year with brightwheel

As an early educator, you spend a lot of time and energy building great relationships with the families you serve. And it's well worth the effort! The happier the parents in your program are, the lower your student turnover will be. Families who feel connected to your center are also more likely to refer their friends and network to your business. Most importantly, healthy family partnerships can help you provide the best education and care for the students at your center!

At [brightwheel](#), we've learned some of the most effective ways to communicate with parents through our work with thousands of childcare and preschool directors. As the #1-rated platform for early education, we're also proud to offer the best family communication tools to make this relationship-building process as easy as possible.

In this kit, we've compiled six essential parent communication tools that will help you share the value of your curriculum, navigate tricky conversations, and keep families feeling connected and plugged into your program. We'll also show you how brightwheel can be your trusted partner in delighting every family you serve, so you can have the best school year yet!

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The Ultimate Parent Communications Calendar

Consistent communication throughout the school year is key to making your families feel connected and engaged with your center. Here's the ultimate guide to what (and how often) you should be sharing with parents—and how brightwheel can help along the way!



Daily Communication

Teachers

Student updates:

- ✓ Activities
- ✓ Naps
- ✓ Meals
- ✓ Diaper changes and potty breaks
- ✓ Developmental observations and milestones
- ✓ Health checks
- ✓ Photos and videos

Administrators

- ✓ Connect with families at drop-off and pick-up

How brightwheel can help

- ✓ Send daily activity updates to parents with a click of a button
- ✓ Parents can quickly check their children in/out using their phones, giving you more time to chat and connect during drop-off and pick-up



Weekly Communication

Teachers

Reminders to bring extra supplies, such as:

- ✓ Diapers
- ✓ Wipes
- ✓ Extra change of clothes

Administrators

- ✓ Upcoming event reminders

How brightwheel can help

- ✓ Easily send messages and reminders to parents through the brightwheel app



Monthly Communication

Administrators

- ✓ Newsletters
 - Learning goals/progress
 - Upcoming curriculum and events
 - Policy reminders
- ✓ Tuition payment reminders
- ✓ Volunteer opportunity reminders

How brightwheel can help

- ✓ Create professional-looking newsletters and send to parents within the brightwheel app
- ✓ Easily set up and automate tuition billing and charges, including flexible scheduling and late payment fees
- ✓ Easily send reminders through the brightwheel app

2x Twice Yearly Communication

Administrators

- ✓ Parent conferences
- ✓ Parent surveys
 - What's working
 - What could be improved
 - New ideas to try
- ✓ Reminders about immunizations and medical records

How brightwheel can help

- ✓ Use each student's activity log to share progress on student milestones
- ✓ Send reminders to parents about important events through the brightwheel app
- ✓ Send surveys through brightwheel messaging
- ✓ Run immunization due/overdue reports and send reminders to parents through the brightwheel app

1x Yearly Communication

Administrators

- ✓ New family orientation
- ✓ Parent handbooks
- ✓ Updated policies and procedures

How brightwheel can help

- ✓ Set the tone with new families from the beginning by sending welcome messages, tipsheets, and schedules through the brightwheel app
- ✓ Easily attach files and handbooks to messages with parents
- ✓ Use brightwheel newsletters to send important updates on policies and procedures

Templates: Sending Helpful Daily Updates to Families

Building strong relationships with families starts with the little things, like daily reminders and notifications. Use these templates to send quick and easy updates to parents about bringing extra supplies, upcoming events, and other important notes. Busy families will appreciate being kept in the loop (and the extra nudge)!



TIP

With brightwheel, you and your staff can send **messages, reminders, alerts, and announcements** with a click of a button.

Template for reminding parents to bring extra supplies

Hi there! This is a friendly reminder to bring *[supplies needed, such as diapers, wipes, extra change of clothes]* for your student at your next drop-off or pick-up. Thanks in advance!

Template for closure notifications due to the weather

Attention families: we will be closed today due to extreme weather conditions. We'll be monitoring the situation and sending schedule updates accordingly. Thank you for your understanding and stay safe!

Template for reminding parents about upcoming events

Hi there! This is a friendly reminder that our *[name of event]* is coming up on *[date]* at *[time]*. We can't wait to see you there. Let us know if you have any questions!

Template for inviting parents to volunteer

Hi there! We're so excited about our upcoming *[name of event]* on *[date and time]*. We're still looking for volunteers, so please let us know if you're available to help. Thank you!

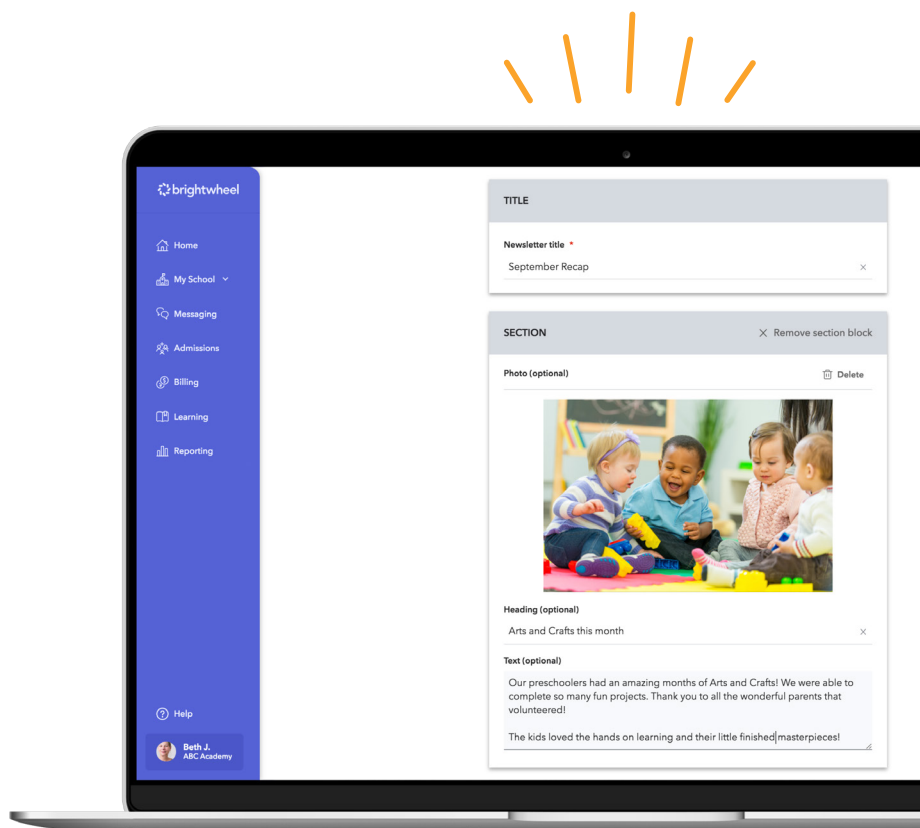


DOWNLOAD

Download these message templates as a Word document here: mybrightwheel.com/daily-updates-template

Templates: Updating Families on Changing Policies and Procedures

To maintain trust with families, it's extremely important to be transparent when you change policies and procedures at your center. By notifying parents right away with clear and gracious communication, you'll save yourself many misunderstandings and hard conversations down the road. Use these templates to update families about changing tuition rates, health and safety policies, temporary closures, and changes in your staff team.



TIP

With brightwheel, you can easily update families about changing policies through the **messaging** and **newsletter** features. Parents are more likely to read updates sent through the brightwheel app than they are emails or paper notes!

Template for changing tuition rates

Dear Families,

I want to start out by thanking each of you for being an important part of our *[insert center name]* community. We're so grateful that we get to partner with parents like you to provide the best care for our little ones!

Every year, we take a careful look at our tuition prices for the upcoming school year and evaluate if any changes need to be made. In order to continue providing the highest quality education for our students, we will be raising tuition rates by *[insert percentage]* for the upcoming school year.

Here's a breakdown of the new tuition rates that will be effective starting *[insert date]*.

	Age group 1	Age group 2	Age group 3
Part-time schedule			
Full-time schedule			

With this increased rate, we'll be able to *[list reasons, such as "pay competitive salaries for our teachers", "update our educational materials," etc.]*. Each of these changes will make a positive difference for our students and ensure they continue to have the best learning experience possible at our center.

We thank you for your continued support of *[insert center's name]*. If you have any questions, please don't hesitate to reach out to me directly!

Best,

[Your name]

[Your title]

Template for changing health and safety policies

Dear Families,

As you know, the health and safety of you and your children are a top priority for us. After careful review, we've decided to make a few updates to our policies to ensure that *[name of your center]* continues to be a safe and nurturing environment for all families.

Starting *[insert date]*, we will be asking each family to follow these new guidelines:

- *[Insert new health and safety policy]*
- *[Insert new health and safety policy]*

These updates are aligned with recommendations set by *[insert medical organization or government health agency]* and were made with everyone's best interests in mind. We're looking forward to partnering together to make *[insert center name]* as safe as possible for you, your family, and our staff.

Thank you for your continued support of *[insert center name]*. We appreciate all that you do, and please don't hesitate to reach out to me directly if you have any questions!

Best,

[Your name]

[Your title]

Template for temporary closure notification

Dear Families,

We are writing to let you know that *[name of your center]* will be temporarily closed for *[length of closure]* due to *[reason for closure]*. This decision has been made in accordance with mandates from our local health authorities and ensures the health and safety of our families and staff members.

Here are some important details for you to know during the closure.

Tuition

While *[name of your center]* is closed, we are asking families to pay *[insert full or percentage]* tuition. This will enable us to continue paying our teachers and cover operational costs so we can welcome students back as soon as it's safe again.

Resources for distance learning

To help you continue your child's education at home, we've put together the following resources for you.

- [\[Distance learning resource\]](#)
- [\[Distance learning resource\]](#)

We understand that this closure may be challenging for your family, so please don't hesitate to reach out to me directly if you have any questions. We are here to support you and your little ones, and we'll do everything we can to continue providing high-quality care and education in every circumstance.

Best,

[\[Your name\]](#)

[\[Your title\]](#)



brightwheel

Home
My School
Messaging
Admissions
Billing
Learning
Reporting
Help
Beth J. ABC Academy

Lesson Plans

New Lesson Plan

< Return to all lesson plans

Lesson Plan Name: Learning at home

Week Of: 03/14/2021

Preschool

Weekdays only

Share with parents

Saved

Print

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Suggestion: Set up a simple routine that is manageable for	Suggestion: Create a picture schedule with your child and try	Suggestion: Set up a virtual playdate with a friend so both you	Suggestion: At some point in the days or weeks ahead, both you	Suggestion: Let your teachers know how the week went, what
Social Emotional				
Help children express themselves and stay in touch with classmates and teachers. Check out this video link: www.youtube.com	Encourage children to help around the house.	Here are some tools to demonstrate proper (and fun) breathing techniques when things get hard.	Help your child create a cozy spot in your home that is just for them.	Your child may be feeling a range of emotions. Help them identify how they feel and encourage them to express it.
Staying Connected	1-1: Counting Our Numbers	I Am Thankful For...	Make a Special Place	Expressing Emotions
Science & Sensory				
The simplest playdough you can make, this recipe requires just three ingredients.	Get outside and explore the big and small things that you see.	Use different sized cups and materials to explore how different household items feel and sound.	Explore water and bubbles with this simple water activity.	Discover what sinks, what floats and practice making predictions.
Making Playdough	Add Lesson	Add Lesson	Water and Bubbles	Sink and Float
Music & Movement				
Make a simple bowling alley to	Help your child practice	Get moving with Yoga through	Follow simple instructions, learn	Use your family's favorite music,



TIP

Within brightwheel, teachers can share the very same lesson plans they create for the classroom with families, making distance learning much easier to implement at your center!

Template for teachers transitioning out of your program

Dear Families,

I'm writing to let you know that *[insert date]* will be *[teacher's name]* last day at *[your center's name]*. I know that *[teacher's name]* is beloved by many students and parents, and we will all miss *[her/him/them]* dearly!

While *[teacher's name]* will always be a part of the *[your center's name]* community, we will be hard at work finding a replacement teacher who will provide excellent care and education for our students. We take pride in our amazing staff team and are excited to welcome another great teacher to our community soon.

In the meantime, please join us in wishing *[teacher's name]* all the best in *[her/his/their]* next endeavors. Make sure to take a few minutes to stop by and see *[her/him/them]* soon!

Best,

[Your name]

[Your title]



DOWNLOAD

Download these message templates as a Word document here:
mybrightwheel.com/policies-procedures-updates-template

Blueprint: Writing Newsletters to Engage Families

Regular newsletters are a great way to keep families engaged, excited for what's coming up, and updated on any changing policies or procedures. Here's a template you can use to create a newsletter that even the busiest parents will want to read!

Note: These examples are based on a monthly newsletter cadence. You can edit them according to the frequency of your own newsletters.

Month at a Glance

Use this section to highlight the themes and topics your program will cover this month, including holidays you'll be celebrating with students.

Example

October 2021

- ✓ Autumn nature scavenger hunt
- ✓ Show and Tell: My Favorite Toy
- ✓ Creepy Crawlies Week
- ✓ Halloween party and costume parades

Parent Greetings

Use this section to make a personal connection with families. Share what you're most excited about for the month ahead or what's been going on behind the scenes.

Example

From the Desk of Mrs. Lee

Here at ABC Preschool, we've been hard at work preparing for October's lessons and activities. Just yesterday, our teachers brought in bags of colorful dried leaves to start decorating the classrooms with! We're so excited to kick off Creepy Crawlies Week for the first time this month too—you can look forward to some pom pom spiders that students will be bringing home next week.

Learning Highlights

Use this section to highlight some activities and lessons from the past month and what students learned from each one.

Example

This month, we had a lot of fun learning about:

- ✓ Different shapes, sizes, and colors—by sorting through hundreds of different buttons
 - ✓ Musical expression—we each chose an instrument and formed our very own preschool rock band
 - ✓ Weather—we made pinwheels and brought them outside on a windy day!
-

Friendly Reminders

Use this section to remind parents about upcoming events, policies and procedures, program closings, and other helpful tips.

Example

Don't forget!

- ✓ Parent conferences are next Tuesday 10/12.
 - ✓ A reminder about our sick policy: please let us know before 8 AM if your child will be out sick for the day.
 - ✓ Now that it's getting colder, please send an extra jacket, mittens and hat, and a few pairs of socks with your child so we can stay warm!
-

Ways to Get Involved

Use this section to ask for parent participation or share volunteer opportunities. You can also use this space to thank parents who have recently helped out.

Example

How you can help:

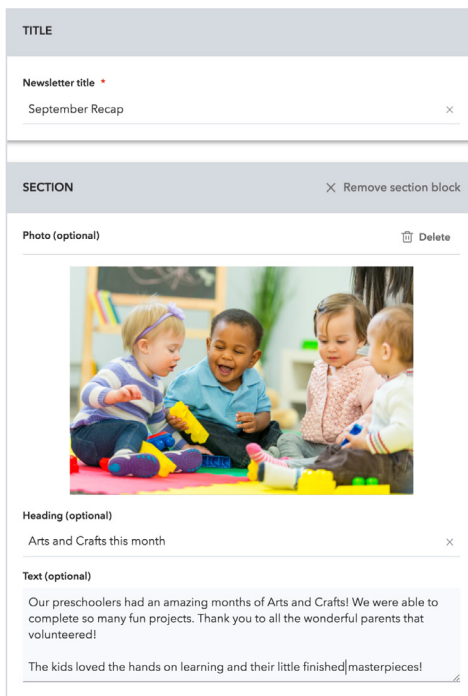
- ✓ We're still looking for volunteers to help with our Halloween costume parade! Please reach out to Mrs. Lee if you're interested.
- ✓ A big thank you to David and Fiona for helping out with our book drive last month!

Kudos

Use this section to highlight any students who went above and beyond in the classroom.

Example

A round of applause goes to:
Anna, for helping her teachers clean up after craft time!



The screenshot shows a newsletter editor interface. At the top is a 'TITLE' section with a placeholder 'Newsletter title' and the text 'September Recap'. Below this is a 'SECTION' header with a 'Remove section block' link. Under the section header is a 'Photo (optional)' field with a 'Delete' icon. The photo shows four young children sitting on a red rug, playing with colorful toys. Below the photo is a 'Heading (optional)' field with the text 'Arts and Crafts this month'. Under the heading is a 'Text (optional)' field with two paragraphs of text: 'Our preschoolers had an amazing months of Arts and Crafts! We were able to complete so many fun projects. Thank you to all the wonderful parents that volunteered!' and 'The kids loved the hands on learning and their little finished masterpieces!'.

Other sections you can include in your newsletters:

- ✓ Community events
- ✓ Ideas for families to continue the learning at home
- ✓ Favorite student quotes
- ✓ Upcoming student birthdays
- ✓ Fun holiday activities to do at home
- ✓ Teacher spotlights



TIP

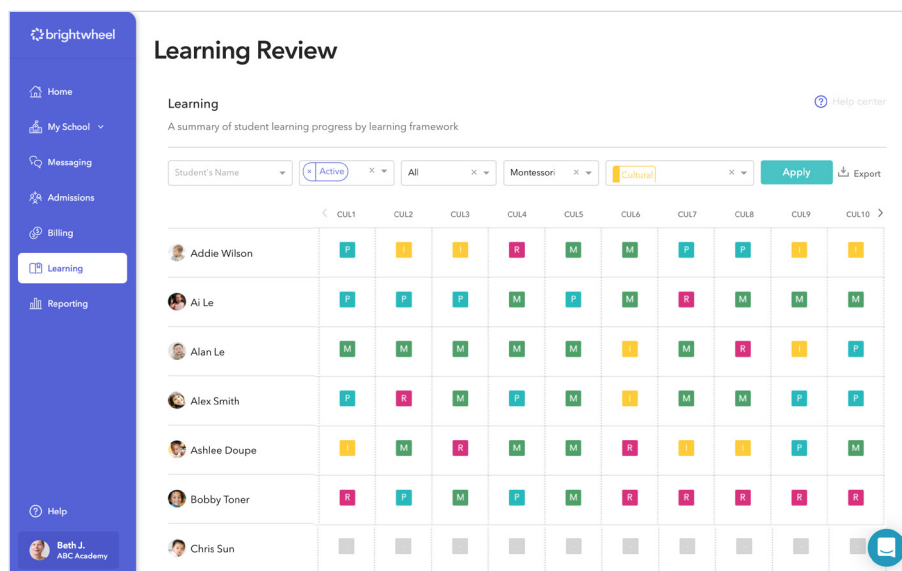
With brightwheel, you can **create newsletters** in minutes and send them to parents through the brightwheel app.

Tipsheet: Communicating the Value of Early Learning to Families

One of the best ways to build trust with families is to show them exactly how their child is benefiting from being in your program. While these things may be obvious to you, it can be harder for parents to understand how your daily curriculum helps their children develop and learn. This can be especially true if they primarily think of childcare as a place where someone keeps their child safe during the workday instead of a place where critical education happens. Here's how you can clearly communicate the educational value you provide your students on a daily basis.

1 Set expectations from the beginning

- ✓ At the start of the school year, **develop learning goals based on the most important skills and milestones** for each age group you serve.
- ✓ **Outline your learning goals to parents** during your orientation, back-to-school night, or through an introductory newsletter.
- ✓ **Share some sample activities or lessons** you have planned for the year and explain how each one feeds into the learning goals you've set.
- ✓ You may also want to **set expectations by sharing what learning won't look like**, such as daily worksheets, and **explain why** those activities aren't a part of your curriculum.

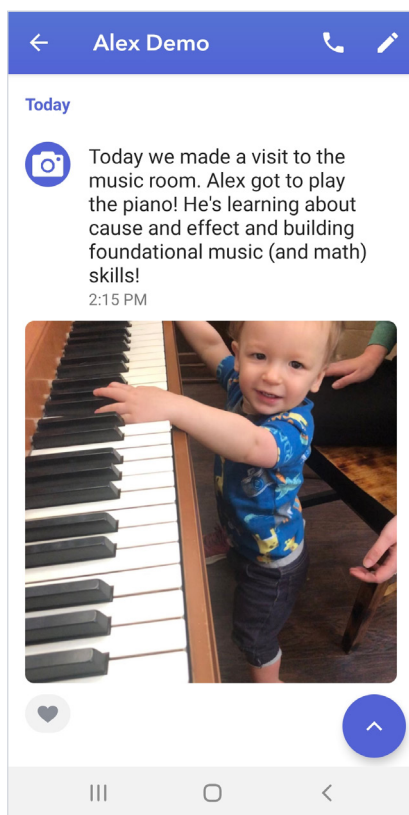


The screenshot shows the 'Learning Review' section in the Brightwheel app. It features a sidebar with navigation options like Home, My School, Messaging, Admissions, Billing, Learning, Reporting, and Help. The main area displays a table of student learning progress by learning framework. The table has columns for CUL1 through CUL10 and rows for individual students. Each cell in the table contains a colored letter representing a learning goal or milestone. A red dashed arrow points from the right side of the page towards the table.

	CUL1	CUL2	CUL3	CUL4	CUL5	CUL6	CUL7	CUL8	CUL9	CUL10
Addie Wilson	P	T	T	B	M	M	P	P	T	T
Ai Le	P	P	P	M	P	M	R	M	M	M
Alan Le	M	M	M	M	M	T	M	R	T	P
Alex Smith	P	R	M	P	M	T	M	M	P	P
Ashlee Doupe	T	M	R	M	M	R	T	T	P	M
Bobby Toner	R	P	M	P	M	R	R	R	R	R
Chris Sun										

2 Share what your students are learning on a daily basis

- ✓ Use a **daily communication tool like brightwheel** to show parents what their children are learning every day.
- ✓ In your updates, use **photos and videos accompanied by captions** that explain the educational value behind each activity.
- ✓ Remember that parents aren't early learning experts like you are, so **don't be worried about overexplaining**. Spell out how each activity helps their child develop socially, emotionally, physically, and cognitively!



Example caption:

Here's Sandra working with some play dough during craft time. She's building muscles that she'll eventually use to hold a pencil, practicing symbolic thought, and learning how to share the dough with her classmates!



TIP

In the brightwheel app, it's easy to **share photos and videos with parents** and add notes about the skills children are learning throughout the day.

3 Share learning in parent conferences

- ✓ Aim to **meet with parents at least twice a year**, ideally once at the beginning of the year and once in the late winter/early spring.
- ✓ Use your first parent conference to:
 - **Get to know the parents** a little better
 - **Reiterate your learning goals** for their child
 - Allow parents to **ask questions** they have
- ✓ Use your second parent conference to:
 - **Focus on each child's learning and development progress**
 - Share an **assortment of the child's work**, whether in a digital portfolio or physical one. Use photos and videos to showcase softer skills like independence and social/emotional skills.
 - Share the child's **strengths and areas for growth**
 - If there are areas where a child needs additional support, share what you're doing in the classroom and **ways parents can continue the learning at home.**



TIP

With brightwheel, you can easily track the progress of a single student or classroom and share these **learning reports** with parents.

Tipsheet: Handling Difficult Conversations with Parents—Without Burning Bridges

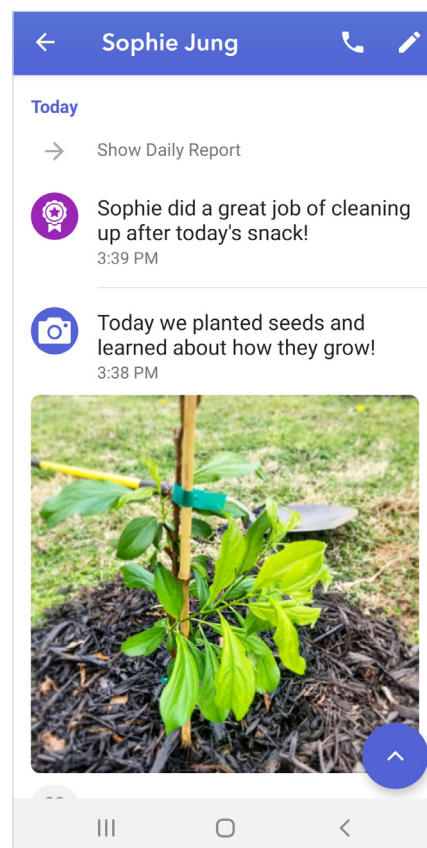
Sometimes, sensitive issues arise that require difficult conversations with parents. These issues may be going on with either the child or parent, and range from common to more concerning. Whether you are dealing with biting in the classroom, potential developmental issues, or consistently late payments, here are some tips from early educators for how to turn hard conversations into positive ones that build trust and partnership between you and your families.

1 Build relationships with parents daily.

- ✓ If you communicate with parents on a regular basis, they'll trust you more during hard conversations.
- ✓ Share daily updates such as photos of their child's activities and progress made on key milestones.

2 Schedule ample time for your conversation.

- ✓ Choose a time that works well for both you and the parents, when interruptions can be kept to a minimum.
- ✓ Eliminate distractions by choosing a quiet place to have the conversation, and silence your phones if possible.



TIP

With brightwheel, you can **easily share daily updates** with families so you can build trust with families throughout the year.

3 Don't present a problem without a solution.

- ✓ Set the tone by preparing some potential solutions to share during your meeting.
- ✓ Provide helpful resources that parents can reference after the conversation, such as guides from the CDC or your state's department of education.

4 Use the "sandwich approach."

- ✓ "Sandwich" the difficult topic with two positive conversation points, such as:
 - Their child's strengths
 - What you love about having their child in your program
 - How you're looking forward to finding a great solution together

5 Empathize with the parents.

- ✓ If you're dealing with a common issue, remind parents they aren't alone and many other families have experienced similar situations.
- ✓ If the issue requires more serious intervention, do your best to empathize while also offering firm (but kind) advice on how to fix the problem.



TIP

brightwheel can help you easily share a **child's highlight moments** with parents—such as photos, videos, and learning observations— to help remind them about what's going well during hard conversations!

6 Consider cultural context.

- ✓ Focus on creating a space where all families feel welcome and supported.
- ✓ Listen to parents carefully so you can understand their cultural values around discipline and behavior expectations, especially if they may differ from your personal views or your center's teaching philosophies.
- ✓ Stay curious and open!

7 Work as a team.

- ✓ Remind parents that you both want what's best for the student.
- ✓ Refrain from finger-pointing and focus instead on what you can accomplish if you work together.

8 Ask about what's going on at home.

- ✓ Work together to gather as many contextual details about the situation as possible.
- ✓ Ask parents for more information about what goes on at home, and provide details about what you observe at your center.

9 If you're doing a video call, remember that you can record the meeting.

- ✓ Record video meetings so you can rewatch the meeting if needed.
- ✓ This will help you focus on what parents are saying instead of trying to take as many notes as possible.

10 Commit to finding a solution together.

- ✓ If you don't reach a conclusion by the end of the conversation, ask parents to talk again after you've had time to process separately.
- ✓ Emphasize that you're confident you'll be able to find a solution together soon.
- ✓ Stay firm on any boundaries that involve the safety of your families and the health of your business.

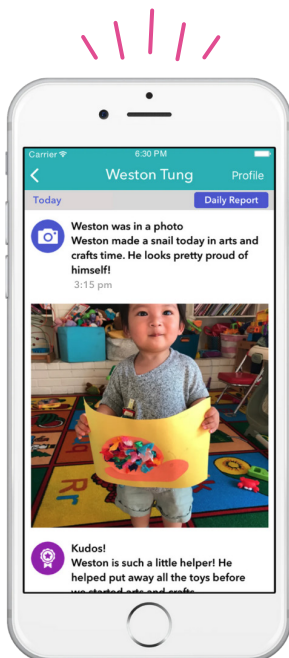
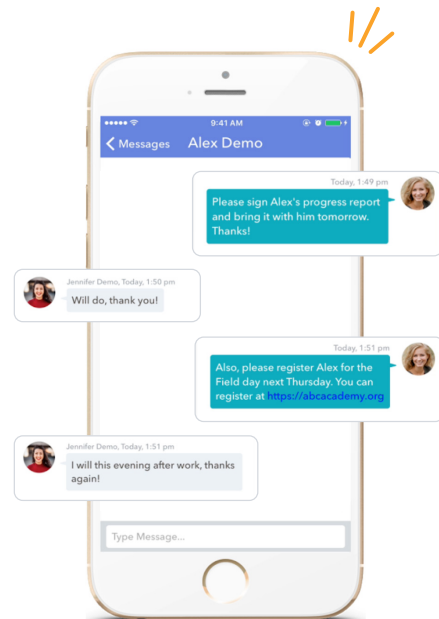
Brightwheel Features to Help You Delight Families

Brightwheel is the #1 rated platform for early education and has all the tools you need to build great relationships with your families. In fact, parents are more satisfied with their school and feel more connected to their child when using brightwheel!

Here are some brightwheel communication tools that will help you give families the best experience at your center.

Messaging

- ✓ Easily send messages, reminders, and alerts to families through the brightwheel app
- ✓ Parents are more likely to see a brightwheel message vs. an email
- ✓ Includes quick preset messages for parents (absent, late, coming early)
- ✓ Send messages to individual parents, by classroom, or to your entire program.

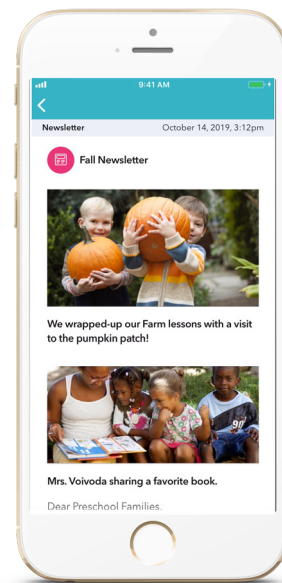


Digital daily sheets

- ✓ Automate daily reports—no more time-consuming daily sheets using pen and paper!
- ✓ Track meals, diapers, naps, observations, meds, incidents, and more with one click
- ✓ Capture learning milestones and memorable moments so parents feel more connected with their child

Newsletters

- ✓ Keep families engaged with professional-looking newsletters you can create and send all within the brightwheel app
- ✓ Use newsletters to recap the month, highlight upcoming events, and remind families about policies



COMING SOON

Document hub for families

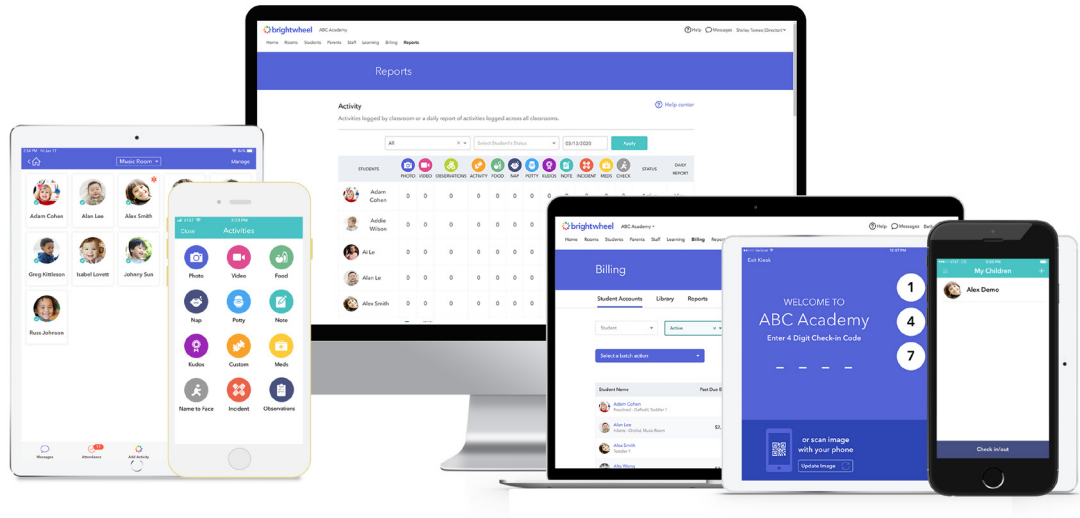
- ✓ Keep all important documents—such as parent handbooks, menus, and policies—in one place
- ✓ Make it easy for families to access the information they need. They'll never need to search through their email or remember where they put a piece of paper!

At [brightwheel](#), we acknowledge all the hard work and care you pour into building great relationships with the parents in your program. We're truly inspired by your dedication to every family you serve!

We hope this kit will help you delight families this school year, and that you'll try out brightwheel's communication tools that are beloved by both parents and childcare providers (if you aren't already using them). We're honored to partner with this amazing community of early educators, and wish you the best of luck for the year ahead.

Thank you for everything that you do!

This Year, You and Your Families Deserve the Best



"This app became an indispensable tool at our school – for both parents and staff."

Paul, Childcare Center President



"Parents have said they chose our preschool because of the brightwheel app. The value it adds to our staff's day and to our parents' days is priceless."

Mindy, Preschool Owner/Director

Discover brightwheel, the #1 rated platform for early education. Designed for early educators and families, brightwheel is loved and trusted by thousands of providers and millions of parents.

Request a demo at
mybrightwheel.com/demo

